Surface: Lizard

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Form Space Grain
Spring 2024

Inspiration

Initially, I wanted to make a stamp that meant something to me, so I came up with twelve different designs, each meaningful in its own way. While working on the practice block, I discovered that fine lines (especially in text) were difficult to preserve. Given this, I decided to use the lizard design, which had no text, and scale it up to make it larger. I also thought this would be a good opportunity to remove a lot of material and practice using different kinds of carving tools.

Process

I made a miniature version on the practice block. I found the hands difficult to carve, so in the final version I made the lizard the positive space.

I used vinyl cut with the Cricut to transfer the digital design onto the block.

I traced the figure with a paring knife and then deepened the lines with a chisel. I used a larger chisel and a mallet to remove most of the material. I started on the right side and moved left. In the figure above, you can see my surface finish improve as I learned to work with the grain more effectively.

To rectify some of the deeper cuts I made when I was starting out on the right-hand side, I went over the piece again with a chisel and then used abrasives. There was one particularly deep gouge that was hard to remove. It was most prominent near the end of the piece, so I trimmed off the edge with a band saw. In the profile view, you can see how deep the gouge was on the piece that was cut off compared to the rest of the wood that was kept.I used a small chisel to add detail to the lizard's face and arms. I used a small gouge to make the left eye and a drill press to make the right eye.

Finishing

I used sandpaper to smooth the surface of the piece and then applied sunflower seed oil, which gave it a much warmer color.

Final Work

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Lizard 2026

Poplar wood 7 x 6 in

Thank you

To Ike for office hours and Jordan for letting me use the shop circuit